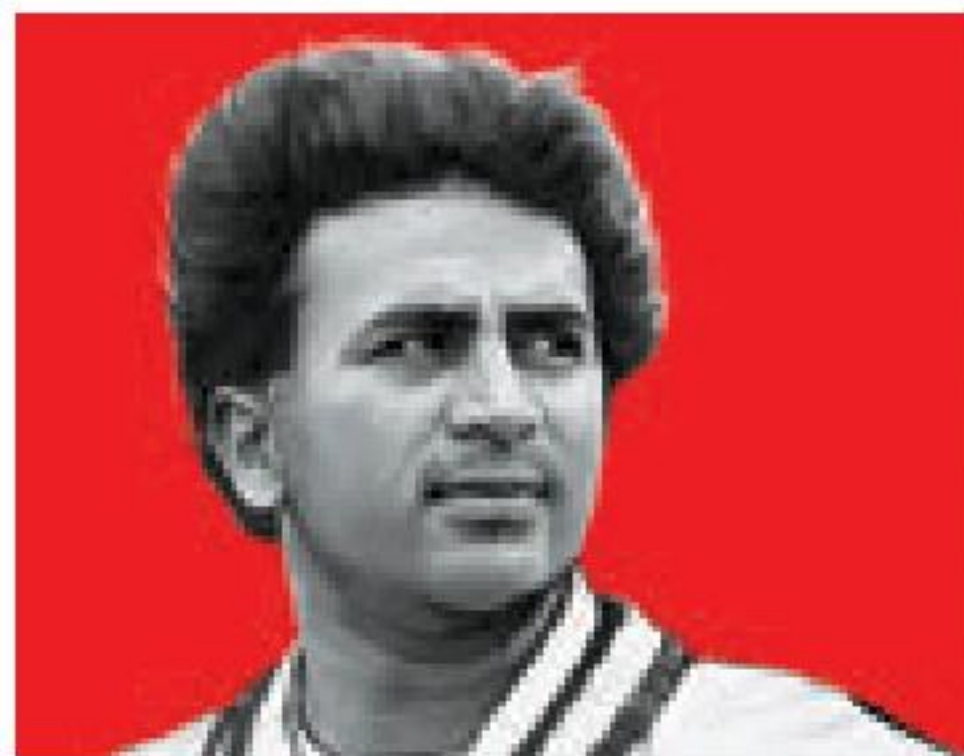




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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MAYBE BCCI CAN CONSIDER SOMETHING SIMILAR TO TWO-YEAR BANS FOR PLAYERS UNAVAILABLE FROM GAME ONE UNLESS OUT ON NATIONAL DUTY

The time has come for the franchises to **get tough and demand** some bang for the buck they are giving the player.

As the IPL enters its second week, last year's finalists, Royal Challengers Bangalore and Punjab Kings, have made a definite statement that this year too, they will be tough to stop. The defending champions Bengaluru started with a bang, making easy meat of Sunrisers Hyderabad, and the Punjab boys have played as if they were never away. Rajasthan Royals too seem to have found new wings under young Riyan Parag. Delhi Capitals, as always, will be in the mix. So too Mumbai Indians, who, as usual, will stumble at the start and then come back strong in the second half of the season.

The teams that have lost both their games so far are the former champions Chennai Super Kings, Gujarat Titans and Kolkata Knight Riders. The teams will have to get their attack right, as early-season pitches are usually good for batting, with the ball coming on nicely. So, while the batters are making merry, it's also

been seen that when there's a bit of spice in the pitch, like in Guwahati, the batters are all at sea. They are so used to getting on the front foot even before the ball is bowled that, when it rises at them, they struggle to make contact. The spinners haven't found much joy yet and may have to wait until next month, when the pitches lose their freshness and, with increasing heat, become drier, helping the ball grip and turn.

The Kolkata and Hyderabad teams have struggled a bit with their bowling, and there's been understandable criticism of their star players not being available to bowl. It's been a long season for most countries, and the bowlers have borne the load, carrying injuries of some kind. That's part of sport. However, knowing when the IPL starts and the recovery time needed, it is only fair that a player not fit from day one should withdraw and give the franchise the chance to pick someone else who will be available from the first match itself.